committed German communist required Liebknecht's revolution be marked as the defining moment of the twentieth century). As Klaus Taubert recalled, Honecker embarked on banning the entire annual production of DEFA films and vilified critical art as decadent and pro-capitalist. 'But the confrontation with art and culture was only the pretext to act against the liberalisation in the area of the economy and to reverse the dwindling influence of the party apparatus.' By the end of 1965, most of the liberalisation tendencies initiated in 1963 were undone.

Unsurprisingly, with so much upheaval, the Western press speculated about the future of Walter Ulbricht. In 1966, the Atlantic Monthly magazine forecast East Germany's leadership would easily survive Ulbricht's departure from the political stage and would continue to operate under 'his two ableist lieutenants: 53-year-old Socialist Unity Party chieftain Erich Honecker and 53-year-old administrator Willi Stoph'. In fact, despite the acrimony, it was Honecker, not the stiff and prissy Stoph, who became more and more important in the smooth running of Ulbricht's life. In 1966, he oversaw details of celebrations marking the twentieth anniversary of the founding of the SED and the fifth anniversary of the Berlin Wall with a military parade, designed to demonstrate the strength of socialism.

Together with Ulbricht, he ate his way through buffets at the inauguration of the first nuclear power plant in East Germany, a gala opening at the new Interhotel 'Unter den Linden' and the 'Lindencorso', a modern new Westernstyled restaurant. Relations were still warm enough for the two to holiday together on the Black Sea for several weeks, while on the home front, he enjoyed time with his father Wilhelm who moved into Wandlitz for three months every year after becoming a widower (Erich did not attend his mother's funeral in 1963). Although these holidays were quiet and almost unnoticed, the old man shunned the spotlight whenever possible and had no desire to abandon his home in the Saarland and move permanently to the GDR, nor did Erich's surviving sisters. In an unguarded comment to a reporter from Der Spiegel at his home in Wiebelskirchen, Wilhelm confessed that his son and daughter-inlaw 'have so little time. I'd rather stay here.'10